



ASP Training for Educators and VET Providers

Welcome to your ASP training. This program is designed to equip you with the tools and knowledge to:

- ✔ Gain a deeper understanding of autistic learners' strengths and challenges, enabling you to tailor a more effective approach when teaching
- ✔ Develop an inclusive curriculum and supportive learning environment, fostering growth and confidence
- ✔ Implement effective instruction strategies and assessments to track progress and enhance the career readiness of autistic jobseekers.



Introduction

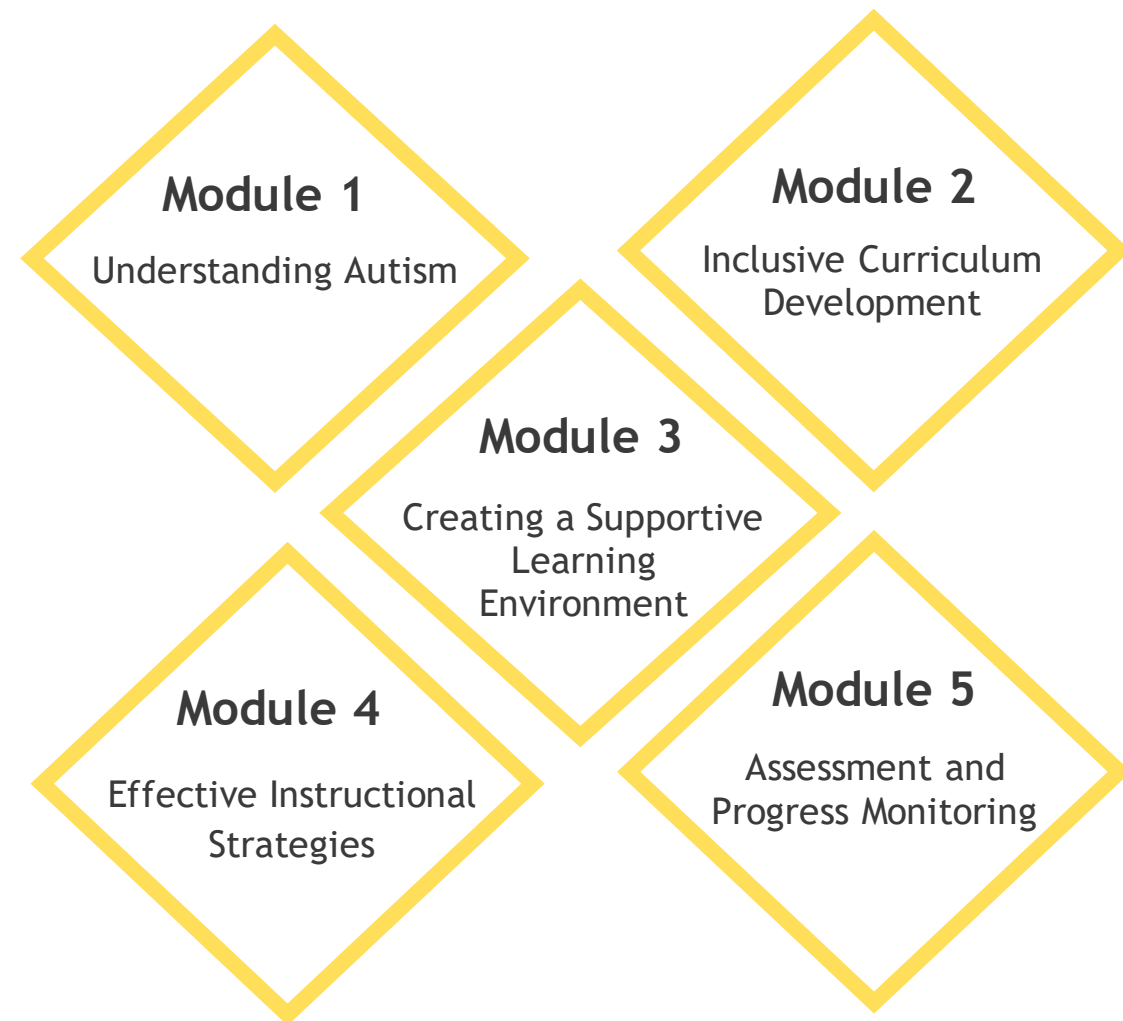
In this training programme there are 5 modules to complete. Each Module consists of:

- ✓ Factors that improve employment opportunities
- ✓ Practical ideas and activities
- ✓ Self-reflection activities

To get the best results from this training programme, we recommend you dedicate 20 minutes for each module.

As you go through the modules, take note of:

- ✓ The strategies you already use
- ✓ What you could improve on



Module 1

Understanding Autism

Learning about autism offers valuable insights and perspectives for everyone. Read 2 principles that will help you get started.

Principle 1: Understanding autistic needs

Understanding the needs of autistic people can be difficult, partly because all autistic people are individual, and all individuals' needs are different.

But we can often find patterns to the types of needs autistic people have.

Read the case study opposite and take note of some of the needs that Ljubo might have.

Case Study



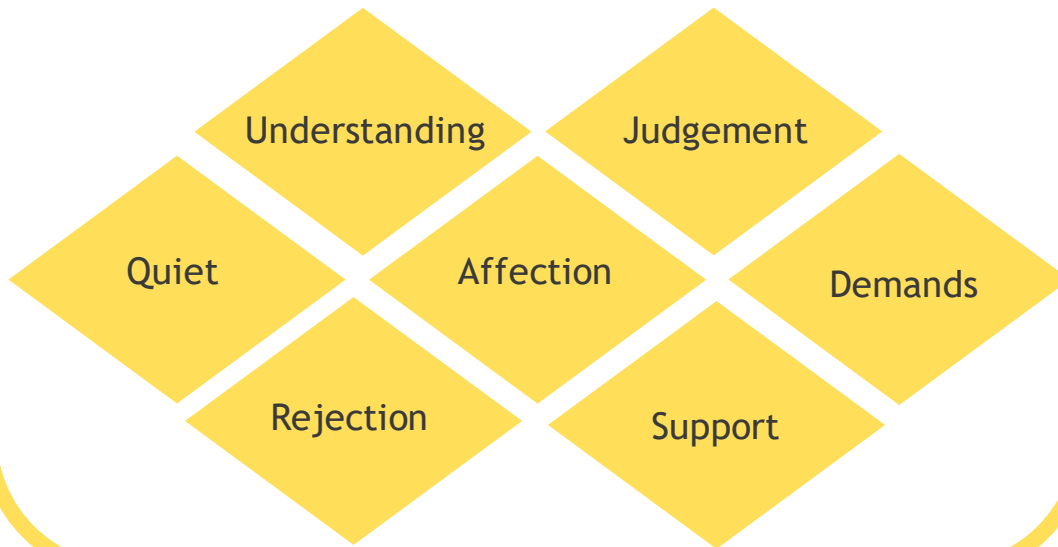
Ljubo is a very caring person, but his way of showing affection isn't always clear to others. He often struggles with speaking and dislikes being touched.

During a training course, he tried to show affection by quietly sitting next to a friend, who didn't understand what he was doing and walked away, leaving Ljubo feeling hurt and rejected. Unable to express his feelings, he became withdrawn and stressed.

Later, when given complex paperwork by his training officer, Ljubo felt overwhelmed and threw it away. The officer's disappointment only made him feel worse.

Developing Understanding

Now you have read the case study, decide which of the terms below represent Ljubo's needs, and which represent the elements that stressed him.



Check your Answer

The following are some possible answers:



Needs:

- ✓ Understanding
- ✓ Quiet
- ✓ Affection
- ✓ Support



Stressors:

- ❖ Judgement
- ❖ Demands
- ❖ Rejection

Over to you

Think about the case study. Choose one action that caused Ljubo stress. What one thing about Ljubo could the people around him have known that would have helped them understand his needs and reduce the chances of stress?



Understanding autism is not only about autistic needs. It also includes recognising and valuing their unique strengths and abilities.

Principle 2: Recognise Autistic Skills

It's common for people to think about autism only in terms of "difficulties" and "deficits". But autistic people, can also have areas of great skill and talent.

Acknowledging both the challenges and the capabilities, ensures that support is not only about accommodation but also about fostering growth and leveraging strengths.

Read the case study and note down strengths that you think Ljubo displays.

Case Study



Ljubo is a meticulous thinker. In fact, his ability to work through problems in a systematic, detailed manner is what often gets him good grades in his assessed learning tasks.

He may sometimes need extra time or support with task instructions, but once he understands the job, he fully immerses himself in it.

Though he was mocked at school for being "blinkered," leaving emotional scars, he now uses this experience in his employment training to empathize with colleagues who feel out of place.

Developing Understanding

Now that you know more about Ljubo and his experiences, take a few moments to reflect on these questions:

1. What skills or talents does Ljubo demonstrate?
2. How could Ljubo's skills contribute positively to a learning environment?
3. Write down two to three reasons why Ljubo's skills and approach could enhance learning for all students.

◆ Over to you

If someone suggested that having autistic learners complicates the learning environment for educators, how would you respond based on what you've learned?

Check Your Answers

☑ Skills and Talents

Ljubo demonstrates attention to detail, methodical problem-solving, resilience, and empathy

☑ Benefits to Learning Environment

His attention to detail can improve the quality of group work, and his empathy fosters a more inclusive, supportive atmosphere.

☑ Enhanced Learning for All

Ljubo's strengths can promote empathy and inclusivity among peers, encourage careful, focused work & model perseverance, inspiring others to persist through challenges.



We've seen the challenges autistic learners face. Yet they also offer unique strengths. Now, let's reflect on this.

Reflection Activity

Read the following statements about Ljubo. Then, consider the questions in the next box.

Ljubo
is a
meticulous
thinker

Ljubo
gets frustrated
that people don't
understand
him

Ljubo
finds stressful
situations
overwhelming

Ljubo
can get stressed
at things we
don't expect

Verbal
communication
is difficult for
Ljubo

Reflection Activity Continued



Do the statements you just read about Ljubo remind you of anybody you know?



Do they point to any unique learning considerations?

◆ Over to you

Ljubo is unique, as are all autistic people. Can you identify some of his autistic traits? How do you feel about his strength and resilience in a learning environment that is not designed for autistic needs?



Module 2

Inclusive Curriculum Development

Making curriculum development inclusive involves many essential principles. Let's examine three of these.

Principle 1: Understanding autistic people's learning needs

The needs of autistic learners may be specific, but in many instances they're not unique. It turns out that many of the things that benefit autistic learners also benefit non-autistic learners.

Read the case study (opposite) and try to work out what particular strategies Ljubo finds helpful when learning.

Case Study



Ljubo's love for engineering began in early childhood. He would spend hours with building blocks, eventually progressing to kits where he built cranes, cars, and motors.

He found great satisfaction in carefully reading the instructions, analysing every detail of the models he built, and organising all the components with precision before beginning the assembly.

However, sometimes he struggled with his memory. He wished for shorter instructions, more diagrams and keywords to help him understand and remember faster. Fortunately, as a child, he never had to rush through his projects.



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Developing Understanding

Now that you have read the case study, decide which five things Ljubo found helpful.



Check your Answer

Helpful Learning Aids:

- ☒ Shorter instructions
- ☒ Diagrams
- ☒ Keywords
- ☒ Hands-on learning
- ☒ No time pressure

Over to you

Think about all of your students. How many would *not* benefit from those things that help Ljubo to thrive? Would any of your other students actually struggle if you made these learning aids available? What else do you think could be helpful?



Understanding autistic learners goes beyond the use of “teaching aids”.

Principle 2: Understand the values of routines

A lot of autistic learners enjoy routines in their learning. Unexpected changes, uncertainty, and unnecessary pressures arising from new tasks that have not been introduced properly can all mean that an autistic learner needs to spend a lot of their energy dealing with doubt and insecurity, rather than concentrating all their brain power on the tasks at hand.

Read the case study opposite and note down areas where you think that routines or variety are best for the learners, and where they might work best for the teacher.

Case Study



Judit teaches engineering to a group of apprentices. She loves her job, particularly the aspects where she gets to try new things with her classes - after all, a bored teacher is never going to be a good teacher!

Judit does her best to make her classes fun. Her principle has always been: if it’s fun for the teacher, it’s fun for the students - and students learn best when they’re having fun.

She doesn’t like rigid lesson plans, she doesn’t like inflexible time limits on assignments, and she absolutely hates spending too long on a task. Her classes are dynamic, spontaneous, and occasionally chaotic - but the majority of her students thrive!

Practice Activity 1

Review the statements on Judit's teaching style. Do you or your colleagues have a similar approach? Note those that apply to your own practice.

1. Judit loves to make her classes fun.
2. Judit hates routines & gets frustrated by them.
3. Judit hates lesson plans.
4. Judit loves spontaneity in class.
5. Judit doesn't want anybody to get bored.
6. Judit struggles in preparing students for upcoming tasks beforehand, and outlining future lessons

◆ Over to you

Managing lessons effectively doesn't have to be boring. Incorporating simple, organised strategies can support autistic students while allowing room for creativity. Think of one of the things you might do spontaneously that you can sign post in advance, provide a structure for it, keeping it enjoyable for the whole class.

Practice Activity 2

Consider why Judit's approach might make learning difficult for Ljubo's. Then, complete the following sentences:

1. Making classes fun might disrupt Ljubo's learning because...
2. Avoiding / disliking routine might hurt Ljubo's learning because...
3. Disliking lesson plans might hurt Ljubo's learning because...
4. Spontaneity in class might hurt Ljubo's learning because....
5. Trying to prevent boredom might hurt Ljubo's learning because...
6. Difficulty outlining future lessons or preparing students for upcoming tasks might hurt Ljubo's learning because...



Balancing a dynamic learning environment with structure and routine can be a rewarding challenge. Consider how you can accomplish this.

Principle 2: Design for teaching

Designing an inclusive classroom can bring many benefits to all of your students - as well as to you as a learning provider.

Read the short piece on the right on User Experience Design (UXD) and make a note of all the design ideas contained within it.

How could these ideas apply to your own educational setting?

Case Study

User experience design for autistic learners should prioritise accessibility, clarity, and engagement to create an effective and supportive learning environment. Here are ten key considerations:

1. Simplified and Clear Navigation
2. Consistent Design Elements
3. Minimised Sensory Overload
4. Customisable Settings
5. Clear and Direct Communication
6. Visual Supports and Icons
7. Feedback and Affirmation
8. Structured and Predictable Interactions
9. Accessible Content
10. Interactive and Engaging Elements



Reflection on UXD Principles

Now that you have looked at some design principles for inclusive learning, try matching a principle with the corresponding explanations.

Principles:

1. Simplified and Clear Navigation
2. Consistent Design Elements
3. Minimised Sensory Overload
4. Customisable Settings
5. Clear and Direct Communication
6. Visual Supports and Icons
7. Feedback & Affirmation
8. Structured and Predictable Interactions
9. Accessible Content
10. Interactive and Engaging Elements

Explanations:

- a) Provide immediate, clear feedback and celebrate all achievements no matter how small to motivate learners.
- b) Include interactive activities like quizzes and gamified learning to keep engagement high within a structured format.
- c) Design predictable, structured activities with clear start and end points to reduce anxiety and build confidence.
- d) Use visual supports such as icons, images, and diagrams to complement text.
- e) Use clear, step-by-step instructions, and avoid idioms or metaphors. Reinforce with examples or visuals.
- f) Ensure everything is easy to navigation with simple labels and a consistent layout structure.
- g) Offer personalisation options, allowing adjustments to sensory preferences like text size and background color
- h) Maintain consistency in colors, fonts, and icons to enhance clarity and reduce anxiety.
- i) Avoid flashy images or complex graphics, opting for calm colors and clean designs.
- j) Ensure content is accessible. Use alt text for images, captions for videos, & making it compatible with screen readers

Check Your Answers

1 $\Rightarrow$ f

2 $\Rightarrow$ h

3 $\Rightarrow$ i

4 $\Rightarrow$ g

5 $\Rightarrow$ e

6 $\Rightarrow$ d

7 $\Rightarrow$ a

8 $\Rightarrow$ c

9 $\Rightarrow$ j

10 $\Rightarrow$ b

◆ Over to you

UXD is not difficult. As long as you keep in mind the ten principles outlined above (1-10 / a-j), you can design inclusive, learner-friendly teaching environments that are both structured and fun.

Discuss them one by one with colleagues. Decide which are the easiest to achieve, and which you think are the most important. Then decide which principles you want to apply first.

Now give it a go!



Module 3

Creating a Supportive Learning Environment

Creating a supportive learning environment is enjoyable and easy. Let's examine some principles to help you.

Principle 1: Design sensory-friendly learning spaces

Many autistic learners find that their sensory needs are far more acute than non-autistic learners' sensory needs. In fact, it can often be the case that poorly designed learning spaces can have a negative effect on the stress levels, and consequently the learning outcomes, of autistic learners.

Read the case study opposite and familiarise yourself with Ljubo's learning environment. Does it have a positive or negative impact on him?

Case Study



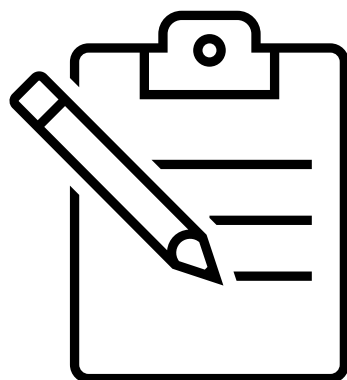
Ljubo's study environment was challenging for him. On sunny days, the light through the large windows made the room unbearably bright and hot, while on cloudy days, it felt cold and gloomy. His desk, which was positioned by the window, added to his distractions as he was constantly interrupted by the noise and activity from the street outside, making it difficult to focus.

The plug sockets under his desk meant others frequently crowded around him, invading his space and adding to his stress. When he raised the issue with his tutor, she dismissed his concerns, telling him to "get on with it" like everyone else, deepening his frustration.



Developing Understanding

Now that you have read the case study, what areas of sensory overwhelm might Ljubo have experienced? Write down your answers.



◆ Over to you

Think about your learning environment. What three simple changes could reduce sensory overwhelm and create a more welcoming space?

Check your Answer

People often assume that we only have five senses (the traditional senses of sight, smell, hearing, taste, and touch); but in truth we have far more than five. Here are just some of the senses that seem to have been affected in the case study:

1. Ljubo's sense of warmth (the hot/cold window)
2. His sense of sight (the brightness of the window)
3. His sense of proximity (people using plugs under his feet)
4. His sense of hearing (the distracting sounds from outside)
5. His sense of comfort
6. His sense of fairness / morality (how his tutor responded to his request)

An inclusive learning space isn't only about the physical set up, but also about the social environment.

Principle 2: Foster social inclusion in the learning environment

There are those who say that autistic people find social and interpersonal communication difficult. An alternative way of phrasing this is that often, those who are *not* autistic can find communicating and interacting with autistic individuals difficult.

This way of looking at it helps us see that communication is not a one-way street, and certainly not to do with “the social abilities of autistic people”: it's a shared activity, and the responsibility of everybody.

Read the case study opposite and note any unnecessary problems regarding social interactions.

Teacher's Perspective

Judit thrived on interactive, social learning and enjoyed seeing her students engage in lively discussions and role-plays. However, one student consistently disrupted this dynamic. Despite her efforts to involve him through questioning, role-plays, and presentations, he resisted and created a challenging atmosphere, making him a source of frustration for her

Learner's Perspective

Ljubo was passionate about the subject but found the interactive approach stressful. He struggled with being forced into discussions, role-plays, and public speaking. He preferred quiet, independent learning and wished his tutor understood that not all students thrive on social interaction



Understanding communication styles

Based on the case study you have just read, match each statement to either Judith or Ljubo.

Learning should be interactive

Forced conversations are uncomfortable

He's spoiling it for everyone

It's frustrating when people won't join in

I get so stressed in these situations

I hate pretending to be what I'm not

Check Your Answer

Judit	Ljubo
Learning should be interactive	Forced conversations are uncomfortable
He's spoiling it for everyone	I hate pretending to be what I'm not
It's frustrating when people won't join in	I get so stressed in these situations
I get so stressed in these situations	

◆ Over to you

Think about times when you've pressured someone to interact despite their discomfort. How did this impact the learning environment and their experience? What could you have done differently?



Communication and interaction isn't only between teacher and student. Let's look at other people who may be able to play a part.

A whole-class environment

One of the jobs of any teacher is to create a harmonious learning environment. With people who have different communication styles such as autistic students, this can be challenging, but it's certainly not impossible.

Read the case study opposite and note where there is good communication.

Case Study



Ljubo usually dreaded group work, as it made it hard for him to focus. However, this time was different. Judit gave the groups a task where they had to look at a problem together but

then each member focused on a different aspect of the problem on their own and reported back.

The group worked calmly, asking the odd question here and there. At the end, Judit allowed students to either speak or write down their findings. Ljubo wrote his and noticed his peers thoughtfully incorporating his insights into their work.

Understanding dynamics

After reading this case study, decide which of the statements below is or are true.

The class was not interacting

Ljubo didn't contribute as much as the others

Interpersonal communication comes in different forms

Answer

From the options on the left, relating to the case study, the correct answer is:

“Interpersonal communication comes in different forms”

◆ Over to you

How might you create a well-regulated social environment in your own classes, without putting undue stresses on your autistic students?



Learning can be stressful, especially with time pressures, tests, and social interactions. Helping students stay calm can make a big difference.

Principle 3: Support Emotional Regulation

One of the best ways of regulating emotions is to *notice* when we are experiencing an emotional state. Accepting and acknowledging an emotional state is often the first step in regulating that state. It is also one of the most important steps.

Think about how you notice your own emotions. Do you often go through life without realising you're angry, sad, nervous, or happy? What might help you to notice your own emotions?

Now do the activity on the right.

Look at the emotional regulation techniques in the boxes below and decide which you think are the most useful.



Understanding emotions

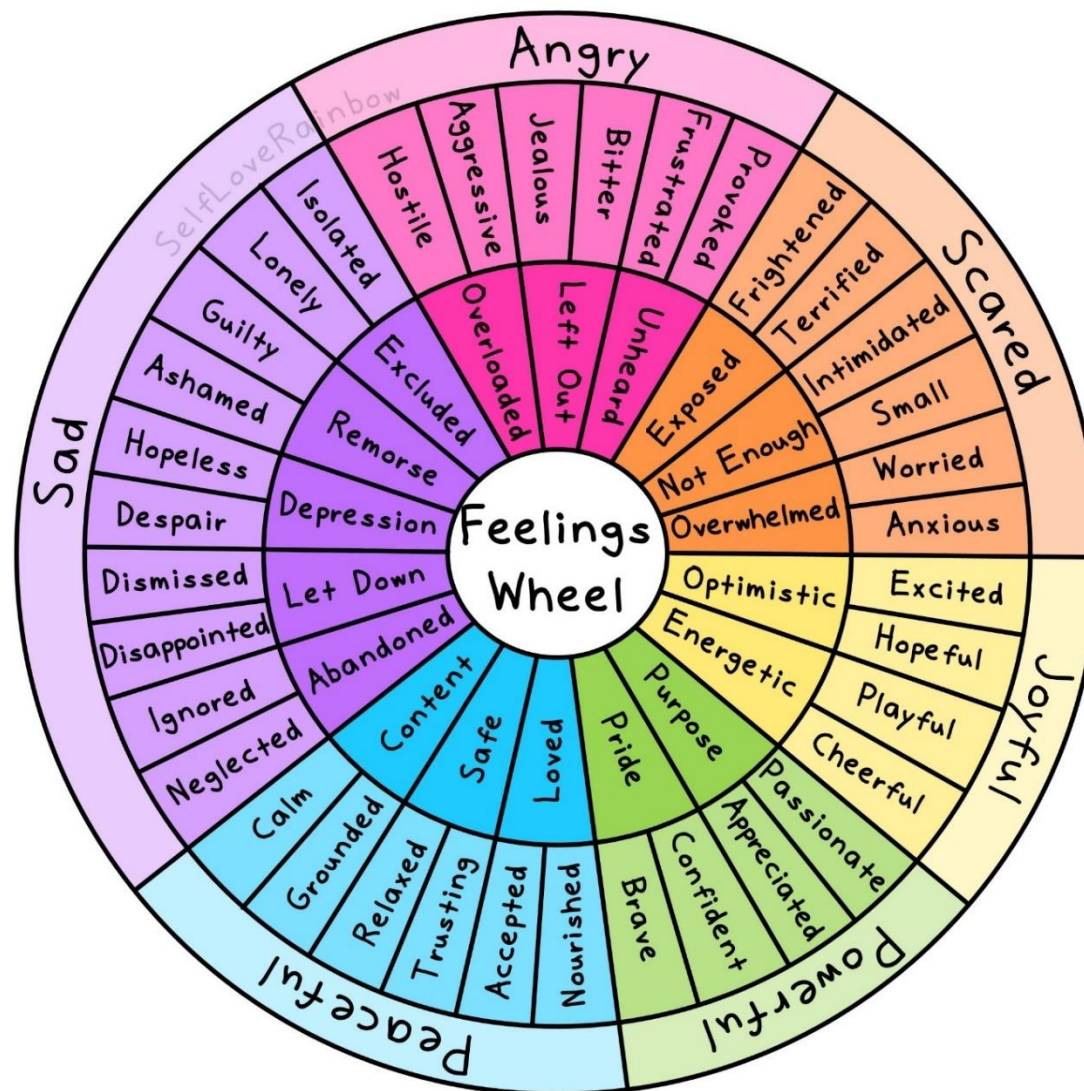
The “wheel of emotions” on the right has been designed to help people identify which emotions they might be feeling at any one time.

Offering one to all students can help them notice, and name, their emotions more easily.

Can you use it to understand your own - and your students’ - emotions?

◆ Over to you

Reflect on a time a time when you didn’t quite understand how a student was feeling during class. How did you react? What would have been different if you had identified that student’s emotional state better? How can you use a wheel of emotions to understand these things in the future?



Practice Activity

Read the case study below and try to identify what emotions Ljubo might be feeling in the situation.

It was quite a busy room. Ljubo sat quietly while the other students excitedly discussed the success of their project. He rubbed his hands under the table, lips pursed, making no attempt to speak to anyone.

His classmates left him alone even if he is a nice student as they know he could get easily stressed. His teacher, however, decided otherwise. She gently touched his shoulder and asked if she could help him.

Ljubo shrugged her off his shoulder.

“No!” he said sharply. And then he went back to rubbing his hands together, more forcefully and faster than before.

Check Your Answer

Based on the emotion wheel, the following feelings can be identified for Ljubo:

- ☑ **Anxiety:** His hand-rubbing and tight-lipped expression suggest a level of discomfort or nervousness
- ☑ **Frustration:** His sharp "No!" response and increased intensity of hand-rubbing after being touched show irritation
- ☑ **Stress:** Ljubo's body language and behaviour indicate he was likely feeling stressed by the situation, as the other students left him alone to avoid

Being sensitive to the situation

Why might Ljubo have been doing what he was doing? The reasons could be many.

- He wanted to be alone
- He didn't like his classmates
- He was upset that he couldn't join in
- He was trying to regulate his emotions
- He was a generally angry person
- He was trying not to get too upset
- He didn't like being surprised from behind

Understanding complexity

Ljubo was likely experiencing a mix of emotions and struggling to manage them.

- ☑ Approaching him from behind and touching his shoulder may have added to his stress, surprising him further.
- ☑ He might have wanted to join his classmates but didn't know how. It could be helpful to suggest he give a sign when he's comfortable talking to others, perhaps in a smaller group or quieter setting.
- ☑ Using an emotions wheel can help understand Ljubo's feelings and offer support in the right way.

Over to you

Think of a time when you felt stressed or upset in a group. Was it because you didn't want to participate, or was there something else going on? Looking back, what would have been the ideal solution for you? Now, apply this to your own classroom: how can you help each student find the right solution for their unique needs?



Module 4

Effective Instructional Strategies

Developing effective and inclusive instructional strategies is enjoyable, fulfilling, and easy. Let's see some principles to help you.

Principle 1: Understand your autistic learners

Effective instruction is only possible when we understand the people we hope to instruct. Autism is widely misunderstood, often as a series of sensory and communicative disabilities.

Read the case study on the right and try to make a note of the times Ljubo is misunderstood.

Case Study



Ljubo sat quietly as the instructor organised the groups. The room buzzed with noise as students switched seats to join new people. “Ljubo!” the instructor called out, “please pay attention!”

It was the second time that day Ljubo felt unfairly singled out. Earlier, he'd been frustrated when he thought an activity wasn't explained clearly. He could almost sense his classmates thinking, ‘Ljubo's so slow,’ even though it wasn't his fault.

Ljubo!”, called his instructor. “Didn't I just say I want everyone in groups of people with similar interests! You need to talk to people and find out what you all like!” Ljubo was lost. What on earth was a similar interest? He liked 19th Century history, but no one else did. Did he have to sit alone?



Developing Understanding

Now you have read the case study, try to work out why Ljubo might have felt misunderstood.

He didn't like his classmates

His teacher thought he was not as quick as the other classmates

The class felt chaotic, the instructions unclear, yet Ljubo was blamed for not reacting like the others

Ljubo's classmates and instructor didn't like him and he retreated into daydreams to escape the stress

Check your Answer

This was not about Ljubo not being as quick or unsociable. The instructor was not able to create a safe environment for him. Everything felt chaotic. Here are some of the moments where Ljubo was being unfairly misunderstood:

- Ljubo was attentive but wanted to avoid the chaos
- He could listen but was misunderstood when his instructor shouted at him
- Others may have thought he was not as fast due to poor communication
- The instructor assumed Ljubo understood "similar interests" without checking, leaving him feeling blamed

◆ Over to you

Reflecting on the four ways we have seen that Ljubo might have felt misunderstood, how would you, as a VET instructor, mitigate against this? How would you create inclusive instructional practices so that everybody feels valued, understood, and listened to?



Effective instruction isn't only about techniques and methodologies, it's about empathy.

Principle 2: Accept that being “Different” isn't Being “Broken”.

Autistic people are the same as everyone else, in important ways: they feel sadness the same as (or more than) other people; they feel rejection the same as (or more than) other people; they want love and acceptance the same as (or more than) other people. Aren't these the keys to acceptance?

Read the parallel stories in the box opposite. Then ask yourself, what could Judit do to try to form a deeper connection with her student?

Judit's perspective

Judit, the instructor, sat with her head in her hands, sipping a much-needed cup of herbal tea. She wanted to connect with Ljubo, but he just seemed so... different.

No matter what she tried—fun activities, clear instructions, or efforts to get him to engage with the others—it felt like she was speaking to someone from another world.

Ljubo's perspective

What Ljubo resented most was being treated differently from his classmates. Yes, he was unique, but wasn't everyone? It felt like his differences were seen as worse than others', and he believed his tutor disliked him simply because she hadn't really tried to understand him.

To see things from his perspective, he thought, you'd need to put yourself in his shoes...



Different Is Not Broken

Read the real-life comments from autistic students in the speech bubbles below. What might they tell you?

No autistic student comes through education

It's not that I don't want to join in, I just don't know how

I try to communicate with people, but they don't want

I don't think differently; they do!

I'm really good at my subject, but I struggle with the way the teacher wants me to learn.

Possible Thoughts

Now think back to a situation in which you felt insecure, one where you felt that other people didn't understand you. How did that feel? What would you have wanted from those people?

- a) For them to just *listen* to you
- b) For them to *feel* what you were going through
- c) For them to simply *disappear*
- d) Something else? If so, what?

◆ Over to you

Dealing with "different" can be one of life's biggest challenges whether it's a group difference, or a more personal one. But "different" usually just means "unfamiliar." Once we become familiar, it doesn't feel so different anymore. How can you, as a teacher, better understand students who seem so different from you



Effective instructional strategies require methodologies. Think about the following principle to work out what methodologies suit you best.

Principle 3: Use Effective Instructional Methodologies

Look at these “methodology headlines”. Which do you think would suit your style the best?

Highly
visual
learning

Picture Card
communication

Remote
learning
formats

Individual
learning
plans

Continuous
positive
affirmation

Take just five minutes to explore one of the “methodology headlines” in the box opposite. Use the internet, talk to other teachers, or think back to your own teacher training - anything that will help you engage more deeply with the methodologies suggested.

Make sure you explore the methodology with a specific reference to autism and autistic learners.

Ask yourself if anything you learned is applicable to your own lessons and teaching style?



More Methodologies

Have you heard of the following method?
What are your feelings about it?

Social Scripts

Social Scripts are concise, descriptive narratives that incorporate specific information about what to expect in a given situation and the reasons behind it.

They are designed to help autistic students understand and navigate social interactions, such as those in classroom learning environments, and are supported with visuals to enhance comprehension.

◆ Over to you

Obviously, the social story in the box above, which Ljubo remembers from childhood, is far too simplistic and childish to use for a student such as him now, it would cause him to feel patronised and disrespected. But reflect, and ask yourself, how could you adapt the social story to suit some of the students in your own classes now?

Case Study

Ljubo remembered when he was a younger boy at school, and he was asked to write a social story. He remembered it clearly:

My toys

My toys belong to me. They are mine.

Many of my toys were given to me

Some of my toys have my name on them.

I may play with my toys or share them
with someone.

It helped him to share and play with other students in a far happier, more understandable way, than before.

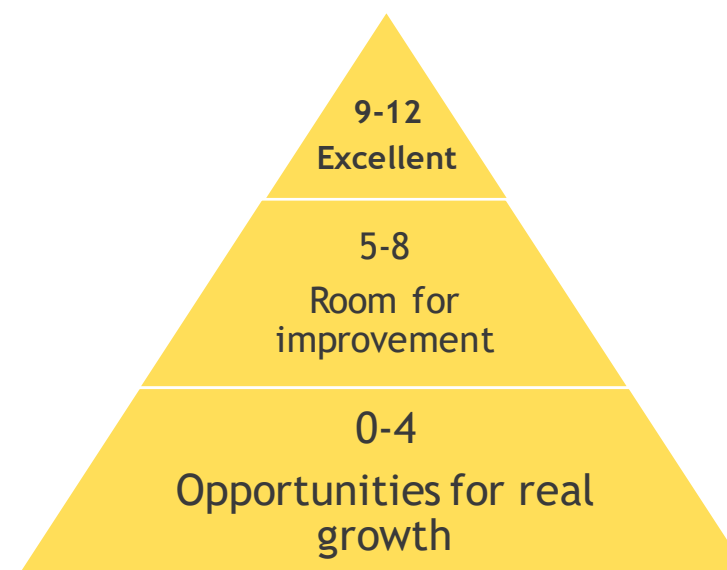
Assessing Classroom Practices

Answer the self-reflection questions below with “yes,” “no,” or “sometimes.”

1. My instructions are clear and direct.
2. My classrooms are calm and stress-free.
3. My classrooms are organised, not cluttered.
4. I provide quiet spaces for students.
5. I use visuals to support my points.
6. I enhance texts with graphics for clarity.
7. I break tasks into manageable bite-sized steps.
8. I label things with consistent, clear colours.
9. I provide clear schedules and timelines.
10. I provide goals, timelines, and their purpose.
11. I guide students' attention to key points.
12. I don't judge students for not understanding.

Mapping Classroom Practices

How many of the questions did you answer “yes” to? Place yourself in the pyramid below:



◆ Over to you

Think about the questions in the box above that you said “no” to. How could you change your teaching so that the “no” answers become “yes” answers? Which “no”s would you start with, and which are the most important?



Module 5

Assessment and Progress Monitoring

Assessing and monitoring the progress of your autistic learners is an easy skill to master. Let's look at some principles to help you.

Principle 1: Understanding Needs

It's important, when assessing the progress, skills, or learning needs of autistic students, that we assess just those, rather than their intersections with such things as stress levels, social communication, or exam-avoidance.

The best place to start is by creating an environment where the student feels comfortable and safe.

Read the case study on the right hand side, and ask yourself whether the student is likely to feel comfortable.

Case Study



Ljubo's palms began to sweat. It was too early in the day for him. He hated answering questions in the morning. To make it worse, he was stuck in a crowded room, forced to listen to the clock ticking for two hours. He was faced with questions no one had prepared him for, and he had to respond in rigid formats he despised.

What if he failed? Panic set in as his heart raced. The world started to blur; his mind froze. Had the exam already started? What was he supposed to do? Why couldn't he ask anyone what was going on? This was quickly becoming a nightmare



Developing Understanding

You will see six options of what might have caused Ljubo stress. Select the ones you think are correct.

Ljubo preferred working later

He wanted to check his understanding of the task but couldn't

He didn't know what kind of answers to give

2 hours was an inappropriate amount of time

Ljubo hated the sensation of being sweaty

He hadn't practised sitting an exam

Check your Answer

The fact is, *any* of the answer in the box opposite could have been right. Even an answer that might appear, at first glance, to be a little frivolous (“Ljubo hated the sensation of being sweaty”, for example).

The best thing to do in situations where you just don't know is try to find out.

Why not consider ways of finding out what might remove the barriers to showing their progress for students like Ljubo?

◆ Over to you

We often assume that creating barrier-free environments for our autistic students (or any students) is nearly impossible, but this is not the case. Naturally, some changes are easier than others. Reflect on one practical way to remove barriers for autistic students and how you might implement it.



Assessing and tracking progress can be practical too, not just about comprehension. Consider the principle below:

Principle 2: Focus On Formats.

All progress checks have a format, regardless of whether the progress check is formal (i.e. an exam, a surprise test, an essay, etc.) or informal (i.e. a teacher's personal reflections on a student's development).

It's good to be mindful of whether the *ways* we monitor progress are appropriate to the *people* whose progress we're monitoring. Education isn't about progress charts, it's about people and their development. Read the case study in the box opposite and decide whether the tutor is thinking in the right direction.

Judit knew the last time she gave Ljubo a progress report, it didn't go well. He had left the test halfway through, completing almost none of the questions, which reflected poorly not only on him but also on her own teaching. The experience added tension between them, and she knew Ljubo didn't want that.

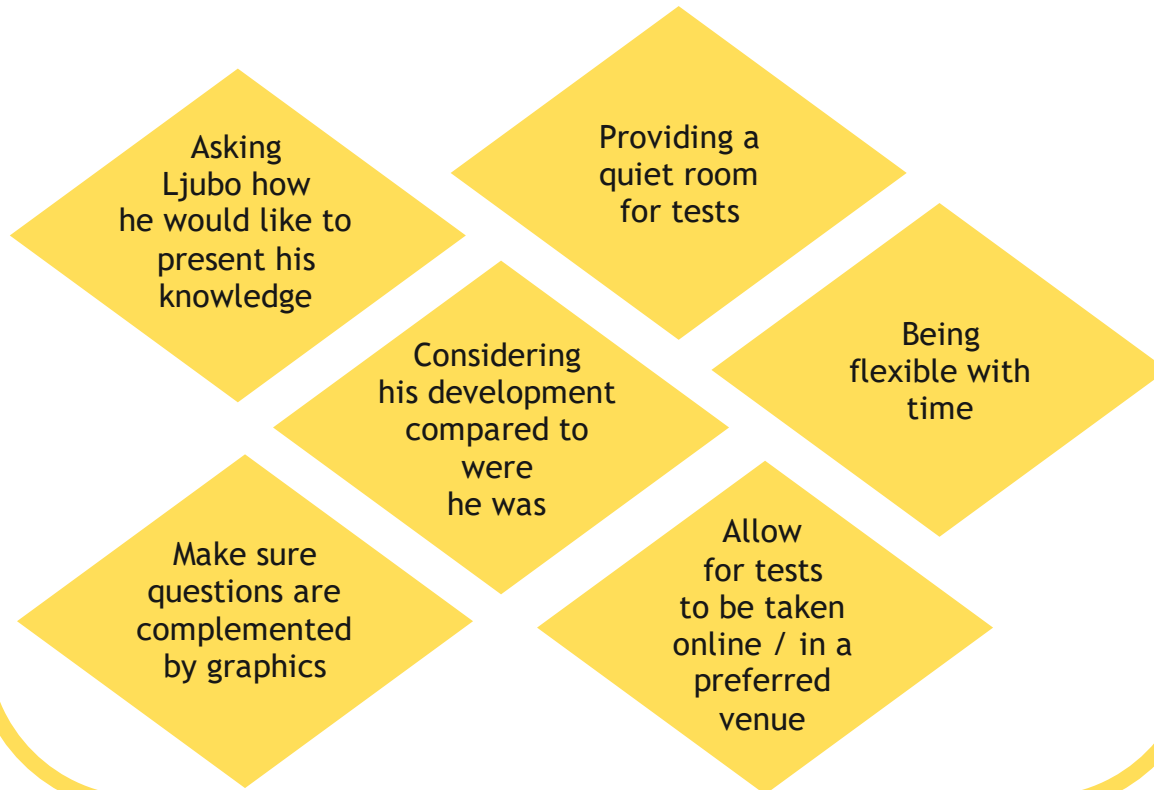
So what could she do?

Judit realised the first step was to learn. There's an old saying: "If you've told a student a thousand times and they still don't understand, it's not the student who is struggling." The same applies to tests. She knew it wasn't fair to repeat the same approach and was determined to do better this time.



Providing Accommodations

Review the accommodations below and decide if they are suitable for formal assessment, informal assessment, or both.



Possible answers

Formal	Both	Informal
Allow for tests to be taken online / in a preferred venue	Be flexible with time	Considering his development compared to where he was
Providing a quiet room for tests	Asking Ljubo how he would like to present his knowledge	
Make sure questions are complemented by graphics		

Over to you

Now it's your turn. You've explored a few simple ways to accommodate Ljubo's needs. Can you list five more ways to support him during formal and informal progress checks?



Accommodations are great ways to think about the formats of how we gauge progress. Take a look at the box below and decide for yourself what type of accommodations are being referred to.

Accommodation Ideas		Types of Accommodation
Extra time	Match the accommodations on the left...	
Flexible time		Accommodation by time
Taking tests online / remotely		
Flexibility over oral or written formats		Accommodation by provision
A personal assistant		
Advising what an assessment will be about		Accommodation by place
Noise cancelling headphones		
Allowance for movement and "stimming"	...with the types of accommodation on the right	Accommodation by type

Being assessed and monitored, or even *feeling* assessed and monitored, can be stressful for autistic students. Let's think about what can help...

Principle 3: Prepare your students

Look at these ways to prepare your students in advance.
Which do you think would suit your style the best?

Explain the
questions in
advance

Explain
test formats
in advance

Show old
exam papers

Provide
mock exams

Model ideal
answers

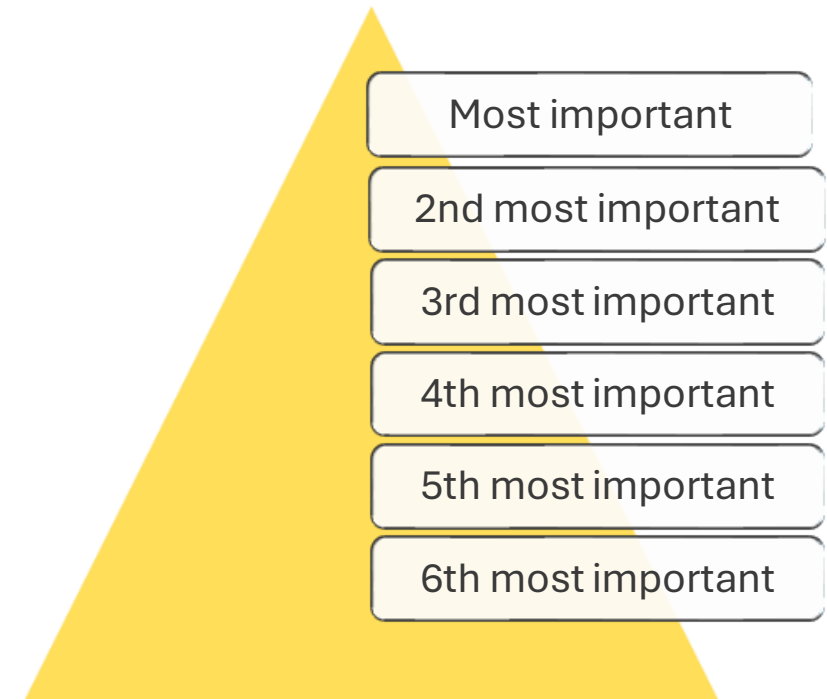
Note:

Although
it's never a great idea to generalise,
it's often true that autistic students
do not like surprises!

A great way to prepare your students for
progress checks, is to show them in
advance what is required
of them.

We're about to review simple techniques to prepare students for tests and exams. Rank them based on what you think works best for your context

- a) Clearly teach students how to interpret exam questions so they know what's expected of them.
- b) Use subject-specific vocabulary and "exam jargon" in class to familiarize students with exam language.
- c) Give students advance notice about where and when the exam will be held. Show them the exam hall if possible.
- d) Allow students to choose where to sit during a test or exam, even offering them a quiet room if necessary.
- e) Practice "exam conditions," like sitting quietly, turning pages, making notes, and asking, for example, for toilet breaks.
- f) Discuss your students' concerns about the exam, openly and non-judgementally, well in advance.



Sometimes, it's good to discuss the best way of monitoring progress with the people whose progress you are monitoring.

Read the case study below and note down what you think is good about Judit's actions.

Judit asked Ljubo if she could sit with him to discuss his progress. She explained she wanted them both to focus on the same kind of progress.

Ljubo said he preferred to "just get on with the work." Judit then asked if he'd be open to her measuring his progress, non-judgementally, by how much more comfortable he felt tackling challenging tasks over the term.

Ljubo agreed, adding that for him, it wasn't about achieving a grade but gaining confidence in trying new things

Reflection Activity

- ☒ What positive actions did Judit take?
- ☒ How did Ljubo react?
- ☒ Do you think Judit did anything wrong in this case study?
- ☒ If so, what could she have done differently?
- ☒ Can you imagine having a similar conversation with any of your students?
- ☒ What about with those who have certain special educational needs, such as autistic students?

◆ Over to you

Consider your students: Is it essential to grade everyone on the same criteria? When under pressure to achieve good grades, do all students benefit equally? Might some, especially those with diverse learning needs, feel more at ease being assessed differently? How can you identify those criteria?



Final Note

You've now looked at three principles that can help you assess your autistic students' progress.

Ask yourself which you do already, which you think is the most valuable of the three principles, and which, if you haven't tried them, you can try first.

Now that we are at the end of this module, do you think Judit has improved in her attitude and actions towards Ljubo?

How do you think Ljubo might respond to this?

Self-Development Activity

Now that I have thought about some of the principles and techniques in this module, I will commit to...

- | | | |
|-------------------------------------|-----------|-----|
| ☒ | First... | ??? |
| ☒ | Second... | ??? |
| ☒ | Third... | ??? |
| ☒ | Fourth... | ??? |

◆ Over to you

How might you communicate what you have learnt to other teachers and instructors that you know?

